PSCI 3328 - International Relations

Lecture 4 - Anarchy and Hierarchy

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Attendance - Divide yourselves in your final project groups

PSCI 3328 - Attendance

Today's Schedule

- Current Events Discussion
- How do we deal with **Anarchy**?

Current Events Discussion

Current Events Discussion

We explored three questions:

1. What is **anarchy**? (Absence of authority, not chaos)
2. What are the **effects**? (Self-help, balancing, relative gains)
3. How do **ideas and hierarchy** complicate this? (Identities, authority relationships)

Current Events Discussion - 10 minutes

What's a current event in international politics that relates to these points and what we discussed Monday? What framing can we use to explain it?

Think about:

- Examples of **anarchy** in action (security dilemmas, balancing, power politics)
- Examples of **hierarchy** (alliances, institutions, authority relationships)

How do we deal with Anarchy?

How do we deal with Anarchy?

Monday we saw the **challenges** anarchy creates:

- Security dilemmas
- Trust problems
- Cooperation failures
- Relative gains concerns

Today's question: How can states make anarchy more livable?

What strategies might work?

Can I Have Some Volunteers?

You are accused!

You’ve been arrested and are being interrogated **separately**

You each must decide: **Confess** or **Stay Silent**

The payoffs:

- Both stay silent → **1 year each** in prison
- One confesses, other silent → Confessor goes **free**, silent gets **20 years**
- Both confess → **5 years each** in prison

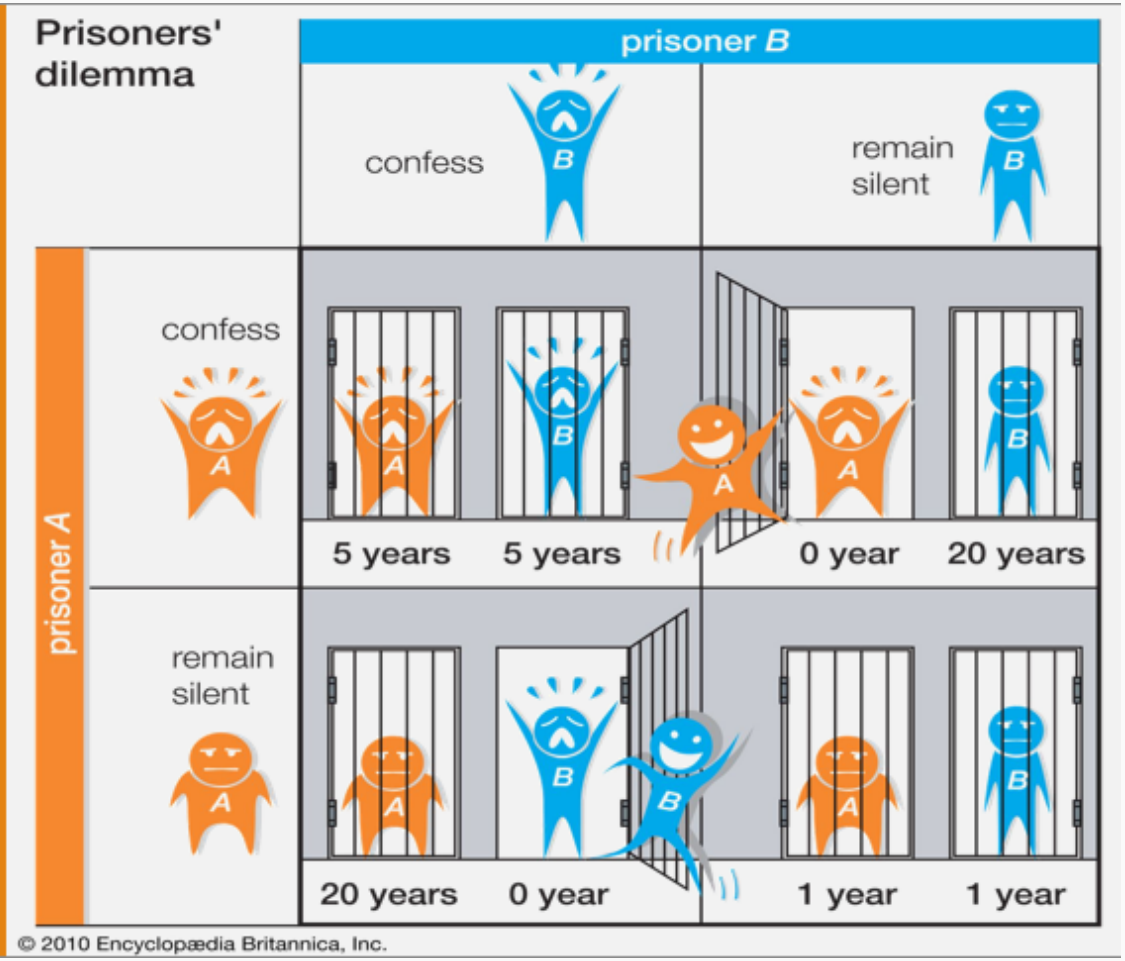
What did you decide?

The Prisoner’s Dilemma

The Prisoner’s Dilemma

A situation in which the payoffs from behavior make a collectively irrational decision individually rational

This reflects the traditional conception of anarchy



The Prisoner's Dilemma

The trap:

- Individually rational behavior leads to collectively bad outcomes
- Best individual move: Confess (no matter what other does)
- Best collective outcome: Both stay silent
- But you can't trust the other!

This mirrors international anarchy

Why So Hard to Solve?

Three problems:

1. **Can't communicate** (or can't trust communication)
2. **Can't credibly commit** (incentives to lie)
3. **Payoff structure** is fixed

Sound familiar from security dilemmas?

Now Let’s run it again knowing the decision from the other players

What did you decide this time? Why?

Extending the Shadow of the Future

- If you know that you are going to interact with someone in the future and can punish them for their behavior, then you are **incentivized to cooperate**.
- Nuclear deterrence and **second-strike capability** Strong incentive during Cold War to strike first if you think the other person is going to strike, but if you know that they will punish you for it then that incentive to strike first is eliminated.
- A lot of international agreements can be thought of this way as well, providing a predictable sequence of behaviors that people can monitor and then punish defection.

Group Prisoner’s Dilemma

Now Everyone Plays

You're all members of a criminal gang

New rules:

- If EVERYONE stays silent → everyone gets **1 year**
- If EVERYONE snitches → everyone gets **5 years**
- If ONLY ONE person snitches → they go **free**, everyone else gets **20 years**
- If MULTIPLE people snitch → snitches get **5 years**, silent get **20 years**

Make Your Choice

Write: Snitch or Silent

Don’t let anyone see!

Results

What happened?

To those who snitched: Why?

To those who stayed silent: Why?

Connection to Climate Change

Why has maintaining global climate agreements been so difficult?

Same structure:

- Everyone better off if all cooperate (reduce emissions)
- But individual incentive to defect (keep polluting)
- If even one major country defects, undermines everyone

Back to the Prisoner's dilemma

- We are going to play a few rounds of prisoner's dilemma in groups, but with a twist...
- ... after each round you can vote someone out of the group

Again, the rules

- If EVERYONE stays silent → everyone gets **1 year**
- If EVERYONE snitches → everyone gets **5 years**
- If ONLY ONE person snitches → they go **free**, everyone else gets **20 years**
- If MULTIPLE people snitch → snitches get **5 years**, silent get **20 years**
- Afterwards, everyone votes on who to kick out of the group (majority rules)

What happened? Why?

Building Institutions

What you experienced: The **voting mechanism** changed the game

It enabled:

- **Collective punishment** of defectors
- **Accountability** for actions
- **Communication** about expectations
- **Information** about who's cooperating

In international politics: WTO, UN Security Council, NATO, Climate agreements

Developing Norms

What you might have noticed: Expectations formed over rounds

After a few rounds, people knew “how we do things here”

In international politics: Over time, expectations become taken for granted

Example: Why doesn’t US conquer the Bahamas?

Not military deterrence - but the deeply held **norm of territorial integrity**

Incorporating Hierarchy

Connection to our games: The voting created a kind of **authority**

Someone (the group) had legitimate power to punish

In international politics: Voluntary hierarchy helps solve cooperation problems

- **NATO**: US leadership coordinates defense
- **EU**: Supranational authority manages collective action
- **Security guarantees**: Reduce uncertainty

Trade-off: Autonomy for cooperation benefits

4 mechanisms

1. Shadow of the future
2. Building Institutions
3. Developing Norms
4. Incorporating Hierarchy

Questions

1. Are these solutions actually implemented in our everyday world?
2. Are there issues with them?

Summary

Core concepts:

- Prisoner's dilemma (individual vs. collective rationality)
- Shadow of the future (repeated interactions)
- Institutions as solutions (rules, punishment, communication)
- Norms as order (taken-for-granted expectations)
- Hierarchy as cooperation mechanism

Big picture: Anarchy creates challenges, but multiple solutions exist

Questions?